A WORKBOOK FROM THE FOURTH TRIMESTER MANDALA

My Fourth Trimester Plan

A place to gather what you will need after your baby arrives: your first hour, your circle of support and what you would love from each of them, your feeding plan, the help that keeps a home running, time to rest, and your birth story when you are ready to tell it. Fill it in with your partner in the last weeks of pregnancy, then share it, so the people around you know how to hold you while you hold your baby.

01 About me and my baby

The basics, so anyone reading this knows who it is for.

My name

My baby's name

Due date

Birth date

Where I plan to give birth

My midwife or doctor

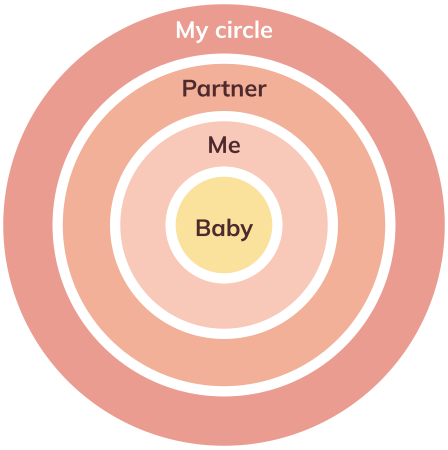
My baby's care provider

Three words for how I want these weeks to feel

02

My circle of support

Ray Castellino taught that a mother and baby each need at least two layers of support, and that everyone who gives support needs support too. Your partner, or your closest person, is the first layer. Around them are at least three main supporters, and around them, the wider circle: family, friends, a doula, your care team. Fill in as many as you like.



The circle fills in with the names you write here. Each layer holds the one inside it, so no one carries it all alone.

My partner, or my number one support

Name	Who they are to me
Phone	When they will be with me

My main supporters

At least three people who can be counted on in the first weeks.

Supporter 1

Name

Who they are to me

Phone

When they are free

How they will help

Supporter 2

Name

Who they are to me

Phone

When they are free

How they will help

Supporter 3

Name

Who they are to me

Phone

When they are free

How they will help

The wider circle

Family, friends, a birth or postpartum doula, a lactation consultant, neighbors, a faith or parent community, a therapist.

Layer 1

Who

Names

How to reach them

Their part in my plan

Layer 2

Who

Names

How to reach them

Their part in my plan

03 For my partner

You are my first layer. Bergman describes the partner's role simply: the mother is the baby's habitat, and the partner protects and supports them both, so they can stay together. Here is what would help me most.

What I would love from you

- [ ] Keep the baby with me, skin to skin, as much as we can
  On my chest her temperature, heart, and breathing steady.
- [ ] Guard the door: visitors, calls, and announcements wait until I am ready
- [ ] Bring water and a snack every time I feed
- [ ] Take night shifts for changing, settling, and bringing the baby to me
- [ ] Hold the baby skin to skin on your own chest when I need to rest or shower
- [ ] Listen to my birth story without fixing or correcting it
- [ ] Watch my mood with me, and help me reach support if I need it
- [ ] Tell me what I am doing well, often
- [ ] Take care of yourself too, and tell me when you need support

In the first hour, I would love you to...

In the first days, please...

At night, I would like...

When I am feeding, please...

When I am overwhelmed or in tears, what helps most is...

Please protect me from...

Words I would love to hear from you

How I would like us to share caring for the baby

What you need, and who supports you

04 Requests for my circle

A card for each person or group, so everyone knows what would help, and what would not, right now. Kind, clear requests make it easier for people to say yes.

Request 1

To

What I would love from you

What would not help right now

Request 2

To

What I would love from you

What would not help right now

Request 3

To

What I would love from you

What would not help right now

05 My first hour plan

Placed skin to skin and left undisturbed, a newborn moves through nine instinctive stages, from her first cry to finding the breast and falling into her first deep sleep (Widström). Check what you would like, and share this page with your care team before the birth.

- [ ] My baby placed straight on my bare chest, dried there, with a warm blanket over us both
- [ ] Unbroken skin to skin for at least the first hour, until after the first feed
- [ ] Let my baby find the breast herself, with no one placing her on the nipple
  The breast crawl can take most of an hour; pauses are a stage of their own.
- [ ] Weighing, measuring, the bath, and routine procedures wait until after the first feed
- [ ] Newborn checks done on my chest, where possible
- [ ] Waiting before the cord is clamped
- [ ] Dim lights, quiet voices, and a calm room
- [ ] Visitors, calls, and announcements wait
- [ ] If I am drowsy or need care, my partner holds the baby skin to skin, or someone stays awake and watches her
- [ ] If I have a cesarean: skin to skin in the operating room if possible, or on my partner's chest until I am ready
- [ ] If my baby needs special care: my partner goes with her and keeps a hand and a voice with her
- [ ] Someone tells my baby what is happening, in a calm voice

The first words I would like my baby to hear

Notes for my care team

06

My feeding plan

Feeding is food and relationship at once. Whatever path you choose, every feed can be close and calm, and skilled help early makes a real difference.

How I plan to feed

- ◯ Breastfeeding
- ◯ Pumping
- ◯ Breast and bottle
- ◯ Formula
- ◯ Not sure yet

- ☐ Skin to skin during feeds
- ☐ Feed on cue, day and night, rather than by the clock
  Rooting, hands to mouth, and stirring come before crying.
- ☐ A visit from a lactation consultant (IBCLC) in the first days
- ☐ Help with latch and positioning before we leave the hospital or birth center
- ☐ A calm minute before each feed: slow breaths, warmth, or music
  Calm helps the milk let down.
- ☐ A breastfeeding group or La Leche League meeting
- ☐ Ask me before offering the baby a bottle or a pacifier
- ☐ If bottles are used: hold her close, let her set the pace, and switch sides

My lactation contact

Their phone

What I would like from others while I am feeding

What I would like everyone to know about how I feed my baby

07 Ways to help me

In these weeks, the mother's work is to rest, heal, feed, and be with her baby. Everything else can be shared. Check anything you would like help with, then choose who you would like to ask: anyone you have named in your circle, or anyone who can help. Each person's tasks are gathered for them in the next part. The baby stays close to her mother; helpers take care of everything around them.

Care for the baby, close by

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Change diapers, then bring the baby back to me	
☐ Burp and settle the baby after feeds	
☐ Hold the baby skin to skin while I sleep or shower	
☐ Carry the baby in a wrap or carrier for a short walk	
☐ Bathe the baby, when we are ready	
☐ Restock diapers, wipes, and clothes by the bed and the changing area	
☐ Keep a simple log of feeds and diapers in the first week	
☐ Learn the baby's early hunger cues, so you can bring her to me before she cries	
☐ Drive us to the baby's checkups	

Feeding

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Set up a feeding nest: pillows, water, snacks, a phone charger, a burp cloth	
☐ Bring me water and a snack at every feed	
☐ Wash and dry pump parts and bottles	
☐ Bring the baby to me for night feeds	
☐ Help me reach a lactation consultant or a breastfeeding group	
☐ Prepare bottles, if we use them, the way I have asked	

Meals and nutrition

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Organize a meal train	
☐ Fill the freezer with meals before the birth	
☐ Cook warm, nourishing meals: soups, stews, broths	
☐ Make breakfast I can eat with one hand	
☐ Keep a snack basket stocked: nuts, fruit, cheese, crackers	
☐ Keep my water bottle filled beside me	
☐ Plan the week's meals with my food notes in mind	
☐ Wash up after meals	

Groceries

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Make the grocery list with me	
☐ Do the weekly shop, or order a delivery	
☐ Pick up top-ups: milk, bread, fruit	
☐ Put the groceries away	
☐ Pick up pads, nipple cream, and other recovery supplies	

Household and cleaning

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Tidy the main rooms	
☐ Clean the kitchen	
☐ Clean the bathroom	
☐ Vacuum or sweep	
☐ Change the bed sheets	
☐ Take out the trash and recycling	
☐ Water the plants	
☐ Keep the house warm, and open a window for fresh air	

Laundry

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Wash, dry, and fold laundry	
☐ Wash the baby's clothes and blankets	
☐ Put clean clothes away	
☐ Keep clean towels and burp cloths stocked	

Errands

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Pharmacy pickups	
☐ Post office, packages, and returns	
☐ Bills and banking	
☐ Fuel the car and check the car seat	
☐ Pick up anything else I need	

Older children

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ School or daycare drop-offs and pick-ups	
☐ Playdates and outings	
☐ Meals and snacks for them	
☐ Help with homework	
☐ Help at bedtime	
☐ Special one-on-one time with each child	

Pets

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Feeding	
☐ Walks	
☐ Litter or cleaning	
☐ Vet visits	

Care for my body

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Hold the baby while I shower or bathe	
☐ Run a warm bath or a sitz bath	
☐ Restock pads, ice packs, and comfort supplies	
☐ Help me get up and to the bathroom in the first days	
☐ Remind me to take any medication or vitamins	
☐ A foot rub, a massage, or a hand on my back	
☐ Help with my hair	
☐ Drive me to my postpartum checkup	
☐ Help me book a pelvic floor physiotherapist, if I need one	

Rest and sleep

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Protect one long stretch of sleep for me each day	
☐ Take a night shift	
☐ Keep the bedroom dark and quiet	
☐ Hold the baby skin to skin so I can nap	
☐ Turn visitors away kindly when I am resting	

Emotional care and connection

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ A daily check-in: how are you, really?	
☐ Listen to my birth story without fixing it	
☐ Sit with me on hard nights	
☐ Remind me that I am doing well	
☐ Watch for signs I am struggling, and help me reach support	
☐ Bring me outside for fresh air or sun	
☐ Keep me company, without needing me to host	

Visitors and messages

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Share the news and updates for us	
☐ Answer messages and calls	
☐ Schedule visits and keep them short	
☐ Remind visitors to wash their hands, and to stay home if unwell	
☐ Keep track of gifts and thank-you notes	

Paperwork

NEEDED	WHO WILL DO IT
☐ Register the birth and order the birth certificate	
☐ Add the baby to our health insurance	
☐ Parental leave and work forms	
☐ Keep a calendar of appointments and bills	

Food notes for anyone cooking

08 Who is doing what

Each person in your circle, with the help you have asked of them. When printed, each person gets a page of their own, ready to hand over. Tasks marked "Anyone who can help" are gathered at the end, so a visitor or helper can simply pick one.

Name

Phone

The help I am asking of you

What I would love from you

Name

Phone

The help I am asking of you

What I would love from you

Name

Phone

The help I am asking of you

What I would love from you

Name

Phone

The help I am asking of you

What I would love from you

Name

Phone

The help I am asking of you

What I would love from you

09 Rest, recovery, and visitors

Kimberly Ann Johnson names five needs of every new mother: an extended rest, nourishing food, loving touch, the company of wise women, and time in nature. Many cultures keep a lying-in of about forty days. Write what each means for you.

How long I would like to rest and be cared for

Extended rest, for me, means...

Nourishing food, for me, means...

Loving touch, for me, means...

My wise women: people who have walked this road, who I would like near me

Time in nature, for me, means...

Visitors

- [ ] Please text before you come

- [ ] Please keep visits short, about an hour or less
- [ ] Please wash your hands when you arrive
- [ ] Please stay home if you are unwell
- [ ] Please help with a task rather than hold the baby
- [ ] Please do not kiss the baby's face

Who is welcome in the first days, and when

How and when we will share the news, and who will share it

10 Watching over me

The baby blues are common in the first two weeks and usually pass. When sadness, worry, frightening thoughts, rage, or numbness last longer or deepen, it may be postpartum depression or anxiety, which are common, treatable, and not her fault. Partners can feel this too. These notes help the people closest to me notice early, and know what to do.

Signs that I am struggling

What helps me come back

Who I would like you to call if you are worried about me

When to call right away

For the mother: heavy bleeding (soaking a pad in an hour or less, or large clots), a fever, a severe headache or changes in vision, chest pain or trouble breathing, a swollen, painful leg, or thoughts of harming herself or the baby.

For the baby: a fever (under three months, 100.4°F or 38°C or higher), trouble breathing or a bluish color, being very hard to wake, refusing feeds, far fewer wet diapers, or yellow skin that is spreading or deepening.

Call her care provider or emergency services. In the United States, the National Maternal Mental Health Hotline is free and open all day and night: call or text 1-833-TLC-MAMA (1-833-852-6262). Postpartum Support International: postpartum.net.

11 My birth story

Telling the story of a birth, and being heard, is part of healing (Kendall-Tackett). Write as much or as little as you like, whenever you are ready, even months later. There is no right way for a birth to have gone.

How it began

How my baby was born

Who was with me, and what they did

What was hard

What I am proud of

What I would like my circle to know about my birth

What I would like to tell my baby about her birth

My partner's story: what it was like for me

12 For my supporters: why this matters

For anyone helping in these weeks, including anyone who may care for the baby. These are the key ideas behind the requests in this workbook, so you know why closeness and quiet matter so much right now. There is more in The Fourth Trimester Mandala.

Her chest is the baby's habitat

A newborn's brain is only about a quarter developed at birth, and to her there are two places: mother, or other (Bergman). On her mother's bare chest, her heart rate and breathing settle within minutes, and her mother's chest warms by up to about 2°C to warm her or cools by about 1°C to cool her. Only the mother's chest adjusts this way. Apart, the baby's body moves into defense: protest, then despair, with stress hormones high. This is why we ask you to keep them together, and to help with everything else.

The first hour

Left skin to skin, a newborn moves through nine stages on her own: her birth cry, relaxation, awakening, rooting, rest, the crawl to the breast, licking and familiarizing, latching, and a deep sleep (Widström). She knows the way. Please wait, keep the room quiet, and let routines and visitors wait.

Milk, and why calm matters

Human milk is light, the milk of a baby meant to be carried and fed often, about every two hours or whenever she asks (Bergman). Stress hormones can slow the milk; calm, warmth, and support help it flow (Jayamala; Feher). Protecting the mother's rest and peace is protecting the baby's food.

Hormones and co-regulation

Oxytocin, the hormone of love and calm, flows with skin to skin, touch, and feeding, and it is held back by fear, pain, cold, and feeling watched or rushed (Uvnäs Moberg; Buckley). A newborn borrows her mother's nervous system to settle, and a mother settles more easily when she is held. Your calm counts: you steady the mother, and she steadies the baby. No one is meant to be the calm one alone.

Her language

Crying is a baby's first spoken language, and around it is a language of the body. Feeding cues come early: stirring, rooting, hands to mouth. Looking away, yawning, hiccups, or splayed fingers mean she needs a pause. Some crying is about needs now, hunger, cold, tiredness; some may be about her birth. Meet her needs first, then hold her, stay calm, and say what you see (Appleton).

How to support

- Do the tasks so the mother can hold the baby, rather than holding the baby so the mother can do the tasks.
- Keep visits short, quiet, and helpful.
- Listen to her birth story without correcting or comparing.
- Tell her what she is doing well.
- Watch for signs she is struggling, and help her reach care early.

If you are caring for the baby

- Hold her close, skin to skin on your bare chest if you can, with her face visible and her nose and mouth clear.
- Tell her who you are and what you are doing, in a calm, low voice.
- Watch her cues, and bring her to her mother at the first signs of hunger.
- If you give a bottle, do it as her mother has asked: hold her close and upright, let her set the pace, and switch sides.
- For sleep: on her back, on a firm, flat surface of her own, with no pillows, blankets, or toys, in the room where her parents sleep.
- Return her to her mother as soon as she can be together with her, and let her mother know how the time apart went.

13

Important contacts

My midwife or doctor

My baby's care provider

Hospital or birth center

Lactation consultant

Birth doula

Postpartum doula

Therapist or counselor

Someone I trust

In the United States: emergency 911 · crisis line 988 · National Maternal Mental Health Hotline 1-833-TLC-MAMA · Postpartum Support International postpartum.net

A companion to The Fourth Trimester Mandala, created by Erin Singleton, a student in APPPAH's Prenatal & Perinatal Educator certification. An educational workbook, not medical advice. Share your first hour and feeding plans with your midwife or doctor ahead of time; medical needs come first.